

TARGETED DELIVERY
Bhikabhai More with his drip irrigation network in Khoraj village, Gandhinagar, Gujarat

75 YEARS OF THE REPUBLIC | FARMERS

EVERY DROP COUNTS

PER DROP MORE CROP (PDMC)
Launched in 2015

Achievement: By March 2024, the scheme had covered around 8.97 million hectares

With India becoming a water-stressed nation, the drip irrigation drive has brought rich dividends to farmers, enhancing yields and earnings

By JUMANA SHAH

THE DRUDGERY

A primary reason why agriculture remains a challenging sector in India is the uncertainty over water. In most areas where water is available, poor management negates any potential gains. Farming in India is by the flood irrigation method, where water is released to flow freely in the entire farm, or manually watered. Experts say only 50 per cent of the water is used by the crop, the rest is wasted due to runoff, evaporation or percolation into the soil.

The dominant source of water for irrigation in the country is groundwater from tubewells (45 per cent), followed by water from the rivers and their tributaries through canal irrigation method (26 per cent). In both cases, wastage is high, not to mention the electricity cost of drawing water from under the ground. The unpredictable weather has only compounded agriculture woes, making it a high-risk occupation in India today. Groundwater-based irrigation is also detrimental to the environment as it pushes down the water tables.

Photograph by BANDEEP SINGH